

WECS Newsletter Production Guide Workflow, Design Standards & Content Planning

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About this Document:

This guide documents the workflow, design standards, content planning process, and publication procedures developed during my tenure as Newsletter Director for the Women in Engineering and Computer Science Society (WECS).

While intended to support future Newsletter Directors during role transitions, it also serves as an example of process documentation developed to improve consistency, knowledge transfer, and long-term sustainability of the newsletter.

The Stages of Creating an Issue:

The newsletter can be split into multiple process phases. These are Theme and Planning, Research, Content Development, Visual Design, Review and Quality Assurance, and finally, Publication. Each of those phases has been split into its own following section.

Stage 1 - Theme and Planning:

Themes:

I recommend starting the design process of each newsletter by deciding what your key themes will be. Will you focus on international/national holidays, WECS events, campus events, seasonal changes, or something else? This will help when you begin designing the Scoop.

Each newsletter can have a distinct theme if you wish, some of which may repeat annually. For example, February could involve reading break or Valentines Day, June could involve Pride Month. However, this is your chance to be creative and take chances with the design!

Here are some of the themes used in the newsletters between June 2024 and June 2026, for some inspiration if needed:

- **January:** New Year's! These newsletters usually focus on "ringing in the new year with WECS" and entering the spring semester.
- **February:** These editions sometimes feature Valentine's Day or spring reading break, or both! As the WECS colour scheme involves pink, Valentine's Day themes are a good way to throw some pink into the newsletter.
- **March:** Spring! Fresh flowers and campus in bloom.
- **April:** Wrapping up the spring term and spring final exam review sessions.
- **May:** Welcome to the summer!
- **June:** Pride Month! Usually features the Intersex-inclusive pride flag, or the smaller unique flags. Or both!
- **July:** Summer fun/Warm Weather! Palm trees and beach vibes.
- **August:** Summer fun and getting ready to go back to classes.
- **September:** Back to school!

- **November:** Cozy fall vibes and fall-term reading break.
- **December:** General holidays and winter fun! Focus on winter break, while acknowledging specific holidays throughout the month. These editions also usually include Final Exam Review Session information.

Planning:

As the newsletter involves multiple stages, planning your production timeline is key for staying on track for your publication deadline. I recommend setting a personal deadline for each phase of the newsletter. Some stages may take a bit longer than others. For example, content creation and design are often more intensive than research and planning. It may help to plan these deadlines by working backwards from your publication date.

A sample timeline is as follows:

Finished Theme and Planning stage by: July 1, 2026

Finished Research by: July 4, 2026

Finished Content Creation by: July 8, 2026

Finished Visual Design by: July 12, 2026

Finished Reviewing and Quality Assurance Phase by: July 14, 2026

Intended Publication Date: July 15, 2026

It is also recommended that you start the newsletter process by identifying the goal and priorities of the issue. This can be done by looking at seasonal, WECS, or campus priorities that should be included in the content or theme.

Stage 2 - Research:

Many major sections of the newsletter involve research prior to content creation. A few of these sections are listed as follows.

Recent Updates:

Two key assets to information gathering for this section will be team communication platforms, and past newsletters. Any information regarding new socials accounts or internal changes that

should be shared with others will be announced on team-messaging platforms such as Slack. It may help to use the edition of the newsletter from the month prior to describe the positive outcomes of monthly events. It may also help to attend as many of the events as possible to accurately acknowledge the hard-working members of the team or volunteers that contributed, thank attendees, and to describe the event itself.

Upcoming Events:

This section is one of the most important features of the newsletter. Information on upcoming events can be found through the organization's calendar, task-management systems like ClickUp, and through other organizational social media accounts. I also recommend looking through communication platforms, such as Slack, for anything that may not have been posted to the ClickUp or socials yet. Make sure you are recording these somewhere, especially the information regarding time and date, location, purpose, any contributions, description, and anything else that should be included during the content creation phase.

Open Positions:

This section may not occur in some issues. During the research phase, determine if any positions are open within the organization or if there are any active calls for volunteers. This information can be found on the website, the marketing section of the task-tracking systems, or by reaching out to the HR director directly. This information should be as true to the documentation as possible, and each position has a Director Document accessible through the Google drive.

Resources or Opportunities:

If there are any opportunities to highlight, or resources to share with the audience, this is the section for those. Again, the information for these will often be in task-tracking systems. However, you will need to look at the opportunity directly to pull more information for the content creation phase.

Stage 3 – Content Development:

This section is where all your research efforts pay off! Here, you will take that basic information and turn it into something engaging, understandable, and consistent for the audience. I recommend starting with crafting the layout and then filling in your information.

The Newsletters are built from the ground-up using basic structures in MailChimp. They contain a few key sections that are prevalent in every regular edition. Special editions dedicated to single events or final exam review sessions often do not include these sections. Below is information on their formatting, and how to create engaging content for each.

Remember also that the newsletter itself must have a title and a subject that will show up on emails when it's sent out. This is another chance to get creative! Add a hook to draw people into reading the newsletter.

The Opening Paragraph:

This is the main introduction to the newsletter. Here, the newsletter should touch on what will be included in the issue as well as connect to the reader. Drawing comparisons to the theme and connecting the issue to the reader and/or current events on campus can be helpful for this section. The newsletter goals that you established in the planning phase are essential here.

Below is a sample taken from the January 2026 newsletter. It focuses on highlighting recent events, connecting to campus topics in a relatable way, and hooking the audience into reading the issue.

“Welcome to 2026! The past year has been a fantastic one for WECS. From hosting a wonderful AGM to board game and bingo nights to helpful exam review sessions, it's been a whirlwind! Now, as we enter another year of not so patiently waiting for the cherry blossoms to bloom (and listening to the never ending noise of the ECS construction), we are alongside you every step of the way! The most amazing thing about this faculty is the community students have built within it and we are, as always, thrilled to meet you, connect with you, and survive our undergrads together. So stick around and read through the newsletter to see what we've got planned this month!”

The Recent Updates:

This section serves as a place to recap recent events, as well as to promote volunteering with WECS, and to provide links for new or updated social media accounts like the discord, or website. Usually it's in a bullet-point format and the recap of recent events tends to also highlight the WECS members contributing to or running those events, as well as volunteers and anyone who attended. Take the information you gathered during the research phase on any social media or organizational updates, as well as recent events, and make it engaging and informative for this section.

Here is a sample from the June 2026 Newsletter:

“Updated Discord Server: We have updated our discord server to give you a new-and-improved experience! Here, we will post about our events and resources, and we're hoping to get regularly-occurring online game nights started as well! This server is open for anyone to join, so don't hesitate!

New Website: If you haven't had a chance to check out our new website, please do! It is beautifully built by our wonderful directors Charli and Ella, who programmed and designed it by hand. Check it out [here](#)!

We have a Volunteer List! Would you like to get involved in WECS but can't commit to a core team role? Join our Volunteer List! Follow up on our Instagram for more information, and keep an eye out for other opportunities on there as well!

Event Recap: Since April, we've hosted a variety of events including a recent Open House! We're especially proud of our final exam review sessions. They're one of our favourite things to do and we really enjoy helping students get ahead. Thank you to our wonderful review session director Sydney and all other WECS members and volunteers that contribute to those events! You may have also seen us recently at ECSS clubs day. If you stopped by to chat with us, thank you and we can't wait to see you again!

Upcoming Events:

This is the section that required the most information collection during the research phase. You used resources like ClickUp, the WECS Instagram, and the WECS website, as well as any marketing requests to gather event information. From here, order the events by date (nearest at the top) and make sure to highlight the most important information, such as time, date, and location. Be sure to also highlight if it's a collaboration with any other groups like the ECSS or Zonta, and to include any sign-up links. Upcoming holidays or campus milestones may also be incorporated where appropriate.

For upcoming exam review sessions, make sure to highlight them. For the event descriptions themselves, stay true to the description provided by the team member who is organizing the event, while ensuring the tone and content match the rest of the newsletter in an engaging way.

Here is a sample from the June 2026 edition:

“Dates and times below! Please keep an eye on our socials for any info not yet confirmed.

Build your own Ice Cream Sundae Social:

WECS and ECSS present a Sunday Sundae Social! This Sunday, on June 14th from 2 to 4, stop by the Engineering Lab Wing lobby to make a free sundae! End the weekend with a well-deserved sweet treat! Open to all ECS undergrads.

ECE 260 Midterm Review Session:

WECS the ECSS are hosting a review session for the upcoming ECE 260 Midterm 3. The review session will be on June 23 at 6:00 pm in ECS 116.

Pride Event:

A beach event at Cadboro Bay! On June 18th, join us for rock painting, pizza, and pop from 4 to 6! Everyone is welcome!”

Open Positions:

Here, highlight open positions within WECS (found during the research phase on ClickUp or by reaching out to the HR director if needed). Each posting has a document with the information that can be found in the google drive. The link to the expression of interest form is on those documents, or copy it from past newsletters. Make sure to stick to the position descriptions exactly for this section. However, the newsletter can include a creative and engaging opening paragraph for this section. Volunteer requests can also be included here.

Here’s a sample from the February 2026 issue:

“We have some open positions within WECS! If any interest you, you can find more information by viewing the linked document, and if you’d like to express your interest, please email uvicwecs.official@gmail.com with your name and completed [WECS Expression of Interest](#).

WECS is an amazing, supportive community that is always looking for others to join the Exec team or volunteer. Gender-diverse individuals are encouraged to apply! Below is some information about available positions! We look forward to getting to know and collaborating with you!

Human Resources Director:

We are looking for someone who has enthusiasm for student leadership, Human Resources, and supporting engineering and computer science students to manage recruitment processes such as application reviews and interview conducting

Review Session Volunteer:

We're always looking for more volunteers to help with our final exam review sessions! Classes we run sessions for include CSC: 110, 111, 115; ENGR: 141; PHYS: 110, 111; and CHEM: 150. A variety of roles are available! Whether you want to run the review sessions, support the review

session leader, or make new practice materials, we would love to hear from you. Email uvicwecs.official@gmail.com with the subject line “Review Session Volunteer” and tell us about yourself, which courses you're interested in, and which role.”

Closing Paragraph:

Recap the newsletter and reconnect to your reader on behalf of WECS, whether that's wishing them a good summer or reminding them that WECS is here to support them during exam season. Thank them for reading and mention seeing them next month! It may help to reread your introduction paragraph and base your conclusion off of that.

Stage 4 – Visual Design:

As you have decided in the planning phase what your key themes are, they can now be implemented. There are a few design aspects to consider.

The Scoop/Cover:

The Scoop is the first thing the audience sees when receiving the publication, and it's a great opportunity to be bold and creative! It can be made in Canva or any other design app and then imported into the section as a photo on Mailchimp. The cover should be eye-catching and distinct, while modelling the theme of the edition and the priorities of the organization. As the newsletter is known as “The WECS Scoop”, the cover is often represented by an ice-cream scoop filled with theme or event related objects. The scoop itself can also be customized to match the issue's theme. Note that below the Scoop is the introduction paragraph and built-in socials buttons. As for the fonts of the title, effects and font combinations (often a Bold font paired with a sleeker font) are used to make the “WECS” stand out.

Here is a sample Scoop from the April 2025 edition, which focused on Earth Day and Exams (Note also the nods to Easter, and to George the Campus Peacock, who was mentioned in that edition's opening paragraph):



Fonts:

Fonts should be clearly readable, and font colours should be distinct against backgrounds. Often a sleek, modern, and bold font pairs well with a light or calligraphy-type font. I recommend sticking to a consistent font like Lato for the newsletter content but using eye-catching fonts for headings, the scoop and anything else you want to be eye-catching.

Here is an example of how fonts can be used as section headers, taken from the February 2026 issue:

Open Positions

We have some open positions within WECS! If any interest you, you can find more information by viewing the linked document, and if you'd like to express your interest, please email uvicwecs.official@gmail.com with your name and completed [WECS](#)

[Expression of Interest](#).

WECS is an amazing, supportive community that is always looking for others to join the Exec team or volunteer. Gender-diverse individuals are encouraged to apply! Below is some information about available positions! We look forward to getting to know and collaborating with you!

Human Resources Director

Backgrounds:

A background is entirely optional, but can make the newsletter much more engaging. For backgrounds, use something that matches the theme and will catch the eye, but not distract from the content.

Here is a sample of the background used in the November 2025 issue:



Section Dividers:

Decide if you would like to include section dividers that match your theme. To create these dividers, design them using a program like Canva, and import them into your campaign as an image.

Overall, the newsletter is about communication, connection, and having fun! It's a chance for you to share WECS events, explore your creative interests, and foster connections between members of the Engineering and Computer Science faculty. So enjoy it! Make your newsletters unique and energetic, just like WECS is.

Here is an example of a section divider, taken from the March 2026 issue, which had a springtime theme:



Stage 5 – Review and Quality Assurance:

This is the final step before publication! Here, focus on double-checking both your content and your design. A great way to do this is to send yourself a test email and view the publication like the audience would. It can be helpful to then ask yourself the following:

- What do I immediately see when receiving the email? Are the subject and title eye-catching and correct?
- When opening the newsletter, does the design maintain its format? Should anything be changed to ensure it maintains its desired structure on all devices?
- How does the scoop look? The dividers? The background? Are all cover visuals imported correctly and clearly?
- Do the opening and closing paragraphs connect to each other and the theme, and make sense? Is there anything I could do to improve them?
- Did I miss any necessary information for the recent updates, upcoming events, or open position sections? Are all time, dates, locations, and requirements clear, visible, and accurate?
- Are there any font changes that should be made to increase visibility and accessibility?
- Overall, is the language clear?
- Are all links working?

It may also help to send the test email to someone else for them to proofread and provide feedback on.

Stage 6 – Publication:

Finally, it's time to send out the newsletter! Make sure to doublecheck your title and subject line, proofread the edition one more time, and send it out! After the edition has been sent out, be sure to copy the publication link and update any relevant social media links.

Notes about the Process:

The process of creating the monthly newsletters is ever evolving. After each newsletter, I would reflect on what worked well and what could be improved. Small adjustments to layout, workflow, organization, and communication were incorporated into future editions.

While the design and workflow evolved over time, the overall goal remained consistent. The process and my time with WECS served to communicate information clearly, foster community within WECS, and create an engaging publication that students looked forward to reading each month.